

The Eclipse Project

Superhero Prop and Costume Design as Narrative Sculpture



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Anecdote

My idea did begin simple. For a screenwriting class, we were to develop our own script for a feature-length film. It began with workshops and assignments to help develop and brainstorm an idea that felt unique and personal. One of the first being a list consisting of three sub-lists. The worlds we have lived in, the worlds we want to live in, and the worlds we want to create. A basic brainstorming assignment to aid in the generation of unique movie plot ideas that have depth that checks out. And the simple assignment worked, immediately I noticed a constant, a world I not only knew about but was eager to be a part of, superheroes. As a kid growing up for the longest time, I always told myself I wanted to draw comic books as an adult. But once I found the beauty of actually being a part of films and visual media narratives, that all changed.

For my screenwriting class, I decided I would create a script for a superhero film. I knew right away if I was going to make a superhero film, I wouldn't want to make just another story about a character who overcame his challenges and defeats his villain with a simple love story sewn in — the basic cookie-cutter for superhero movies. So I started to look at the stories that do things differently: *Kick-Ass*, *Super*, *Hancock*, and *Unbreakable*. I could tell that these types of stories were the ones I wanted to tell. I thought of another film, *Joker*, an incredibly impactful film about the Batman villain, the Joker, and his origin story. It was a movie about the birth of a villain. And now it was coming together for me.

I put together my pitch, structured out plot points, and brought it to my class. I explained how the story exists within a world where superheroes exist, and begins with the death of a real one on live television. Our main character is not a superhero himself, but sees the livestream and

is inspired to become one. Elias, the protagonist, tries over and over to do the right thing (even putting himself in harm's way), but ultimately ends up hurting everyone else around him. This failure sends Elias down a dark path. The twist is that this was never an origin story in the traditional sense. It is the birth of a villain.

Characters from the Marvel universe, like Loki and Magneto, are popular because they follow a villain on their arc to becoming a hero. There is something very compelling about watching this transformation. In *Joker*, I found an atypical narrative, in which the villain does not necessarily become a hero, but rather the audience understands how he came to be the way he is. In *Kick-Ass*, I found a character inspired by the comic books he read. For my film, I decided I wanted to merge these themes.

In class, we learned about the typical structures of films, specifically sixteen different types of movie arcs that can be used as models to follow within the formula of feature films. The first few classmates that I shared my project idea with gave good advice. Here and there, such and such could work as a device that comes into play later, dialogue could be tweaked to enhance clarity or realness.

But that positive feedback came to a halt when my professor shared that she lacked confidence in my vision.

“This does not work the way you think it does,” my professor said.

“How so?” I asked.

“Well, in your story summary, you say that it is supposed to have a comedy element, and that just isn’t coming through with your current script.”

I have been a part of a lot of film critiques over the years, from friends, family, and cynics alike, so I have learned the skill of sitting back and listening rather than trying to argue. In

fact, this is a skill that I pride myself on, and I am usually able to sit back and listen. However, in this case, I found it hard to sit silently. I defended my view.

“Yeah, well, it's not supposed to be a traditional setup of jokes and slapstick humor... It's more of a situational humor, I'm not expecting people to laugh out loud.” I said.

“Uhm, so then that is something you can continue to work on? Additionally, it's not exactly clear why this character is doing all of this.”

“I'm not sure I understand,” I said. “The opening sequence begins with a gruesome death televised. What I'm trying to get at is that this is the main character's moment of inspiration.”

“Yeah, that's just not enough,” my professor said. “As the audience, we should understand why this character is motivated. What experience in his life is pushing him to act out and attempt to be heroic? Maybe something happened to him when he was younger, or something else. I didn't invent these rules, but I would recommend you revisit the Save the Cat structure we've been using. Right now, the story isn't hitting those beats.”

I looked around the classroom at a small group of students who were half listening, some staring at their computers, others out the window, mouths slightly open. I paused for a moment and thought to myself, this is a professor, they have knowledge and experience, and likely understand this better than I do. I shouldn't argue.

“I don't agree,” I said.

I left the class angry; it felt like the professor didn't even try to understand what I was trying to do. It felt like I was being forced into a box. Fit your story into one of the sixteen story types, or it doesn't work. You need an origin, or it fails. You're missing something. Your story isn't right. It's not funny.

Artist Statement

Growing up, I often felt slightly out of step with the pace of the classroom. Throughout elementary and middle school, I was placed in support classes and given accommodations through an Individualized Education Program because my learning was categorized as having “slow processing speed.” At the time, that label explained why I absorbed information differently and needed more time to work through material. During those years, my uncle Steve introduced me to comic books, and they quickly became an escape.

I became fascinated with characters defined by transformation, from the X-Men to animated TV series like *Ben 10* and *Avatar*, and films such as *The Karate Kid* and *Back to the Future*. These were stories about people who began out of place and eventually discovered power through change, and that idea stayed with me. It wasn’t until high school that I received an official ADHD diagnosis of the inattentive type, and many of the patterns in my life started to make sense. The obsessions, hobbies, and creative fixations that had always consumed my attention suddenly had a clearer structure. Looking back, those early narratives of transformation shaped the way I think about characters.

With a passion for filmmaking, writing, and digital fabrication, I’ve always been drawn to the moment where something imagined in my head becomes something I can hold. My Senior Comp expands on a project I began last year: a single helmet prototype. That project grew into a full series of sculptural iterations that trace the evolution of a character I’ve been building for years: The Phoenix, also known as The Eclipse. What defines this project is that it is completely interdisciplinary and weaves together the skills I have been honing throughout college.

As an Art, Science & Innovation major with minors in Filmmaking and Writing, my work naturally sits at the intersection of several worlds. The visual storytelling I learned through filmmaking shaped how I thought about space, staging, and the life cycle of a prop — from how a room becomes a scene, to why every hero object on a real set exists in multiple versions. Writing taught me how characters develop, fracture, and rebuild, which directly influences each stage of the helmet's physical decay and transformation. My ASI studies gave me the tools to actualize these objects using 3D modeling, laser cutting, 3D printing, and digital-to-physical workflows to prototype, iterate, and refine.

During my 3rd year at Allegheny, I studied abroad in Italy and added yet another layer to my ever-evolving project. I spent months learning screenprinting and developing a tactile sensitivity to surface and textile. The time I spent in Rome shaped the way I think about material wear, weight, patina, and the feel of lived-in objects. It changed how I visualize what my character touches, wears, and carries.

This comp is a project about transformation; both the transformation of a hero through the destruction of his helmet, and the transformation of an idea through the long process of design, fabrication, and storytelling.

Chapter 1: Deconstructing the Superhero Formula

The Formula

A central theme of *The Eclipse* is the collapse of the hero archetype. The protagonist believes that taking action is always better than doing nothing and that intent is enough to justify involvement. This becomes his tragic flaw. He confuses urgency with responsibility and acts out of a belief that stepping in is inherently moral. In reality, his efforts to intervene in dangerous situations consistently result in unintended harm. The protagonist slowly deteriorates under the pressure of his own misguided convictions, ultimately leading to a violent breaking point. The story positions complacency and impulsive action as two extremes of the same problem and explores how a desire to do good can warp into self-delusion when unexamined.

To understand why *The Eclipse* works the way it does, it helps to understand the tradition it is working against. Superhero narratives follow recognizable patterns, and those patterns carry real weight with audiences. They create expectations about who a protagonist is allowed to be, how suffering is supposed to transform a person, and what a story owes its viewer by the end. The films that shaped my thinking about this project are ones that tested those expectations, sometimes by bending them, sometimes by breaking them entirely. Looking closely at those films helped me understand what my own story needed to refuse.

It is important to acknowledge that the hero story is not a Hollywood invention. It predates cinema entirely, reaching back through religious tradition, mythology, and oral storytelling. Figures like Jesus, Hercules, and Zeus occupy the same structural role as Spider-Man or Batman—a chosen individual, one who has often experienced trauma, rises to

protect others and restore order. Author Joseph Campbell mapped this pattern across cultures and called it the monomyth, describing it as the structure by which "a hero ventures forth from the world of common day into a region of supernatural wonder: fabulous forces are there encountered and a decisive victory is won: the hero comes back from this mysterious adventure with the power to bestow boons on his fellow man".¹ The pattern is so deeply embedded in human storytelling that audiences feel it even when they cannot name it. By the time "the hero" reached Hollywood, it had simply been codified, given act breaks and beat sheets, packaged for mass consumption. When that pattern finally reached the superhero film, it arrived fully formed, and audiences already knew how the story was supposed to end.

Films communicate meaning through structured narratives that organize events in ways audiences can follow. As Bordwell and Thompson explain, "a narrative is a chain of events linked by cause and effect and occurring in time and space,"² meaning that film stories present events that logically lead to one another so audiences can track how actions produce consequences. Understanding how that chain is constructed requires a distinction between story and plot. Bordwell and Thompson define the story as the complete set of events in a narrative, both those explicitly shown and those the viewer infers, while the plot is everything visibly and audibly present in the film itself.³ Films reveal only selected information, and audiences mentally reconstruct the larger world from what they see and hear. This selectivity is not passive. The filmmaker actively shapes how that reconstruction happens. As Bordwell and Thompson note, "the filmmaker creates a constant interplay between similarity and difference, and repetition and variation," a process that leads viewers into active engagement with the film's developing

¹ Joseph Campbell, *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 3rd ed. (Novato, CA: New World Library, 2008), 23.

² David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson, *Film Art: An Introduction*, 10th ed. (New York: McGraw-Hill, 2013), 73.

³ Bordwell and Thompson, *Film Art*, 74.

system.⁴ Films repeat and vary elements over time, training audiences to recognize patterns and follow how the narrative unfolds. These tools, causality, selective disclosure, repetition and variation, form the basic grammar of cinematic storytelling, and they are the same tools that genre formulas rely on and that subversive films choose to disrupt.

Much of mainstream filmmaking organizes that grammar into repeatable structures. Bordwell and Thompson identify one of the most common as "the goal-oriented plot, in which a character takes steps to achieve an object or condition", a pattern that places a character's pursuit at the center of the story and lets every event build around it.⁵ Screenwriting manuals take this further by turning structure into formula. Blake Snyder's *Save the Cat!* argues that the foundation of any successful screenplay is a premise so clear it can be understood immediately, what he calls the single most important question a writer must answer: "What is it?".⁶ From that premise, Snyder maps out a sequence of fifteen narrative beats that guide a film from opening image to final frame, each one functioning as a checkpoint the story is expected to hit.⁷ The model builds toward a specific kind of ending. In Snyder's framework, the finale is where everything the protagonist has learned is finally applied, where the central conflict resolves, and where the hero's arc arrives at triumph.⁸ The formula is effective because it is legible. Audiences feel the rhythm even when they do not know the terminology, and that familiarity is exactly what makes it possible to break.

⁴ Bordwell and Thompson, *Film Art*, 70.

⁵ Bordwell and Thompson, *Film Art*, 85.

⁶ Blake Snyder, *Save the Cat! The Last Book on Screenwriting You'll Ever Need* (Studio City, CA: Michael Wiese Productions, 2005), 20.

⁷ Snyder, *Save the Cat!*, 10.

⁸ Snyder, *Save the Cat!*, 118–19.

Within this broader formula, superhero films occupy a specific subcategory with their own set of expectations. Snyder defines the superhero genre as one built around a hero who possesses a special power, where the story is primarily concerned with the hero learning how to use that power.⁹ The structure is not just about having abilities but about earning them through experience, failure, and moral growth. Snyder reinforces this by identifying a key narrative beat in which "the hero discovers a strength he didn't know he had"¹⁰ a moment that typically arrives near the climax and signals that the character has completed the internal transformation the story has been building toward. This framework assumes that power and responsibility are linked, that the journey from ordinary person to hero is a process of becoming worthy of the role. It is a pattern visible across decades of superhero filmmaking. In Sam Raimi's *Spider-Man*, Peter Parker receives his abilities by accident but spends the entire film learning what they cost him, losing his uncle, alienating the people closest to him, and confronting the idea that power ignored is its own form of violence. The origin story is not the spider bite. The origin story is the guilt, the loss, and the slow acceptance of a burden he did not ask for. Batman follows a similar logic from a different direction. Bruce Wayne is not granted power; he builds it. He trains, travels, constructs an identity, and returns to Gotham with a purpose shaped entirely by trauma. But the arc still resolves the same way: the character earns the right to act, and the audience is given a reason to believe in the person behind the mask. In both cases, the formula depends on a protagonist who is tested, shaped, and ultimately validated by the narrative. The audience watches someone become a hero and feels that the transformation is deserved. That sense of

⁹ Snyder, *Save the Cat!*, 27.

¹⁰ Snyder, *Save the Cat!*, 27.

earned identity is what holds the formula together, and it is also what makes the formula so satisfying to dismantle.

Kick-Ass

Matthew Vaughn's *Kick-Ass* (2010) is one of the most direct challenges to the genre's assumptions about who is allowed to become a hero and what happens when someone without the right qualifications tries. The film follows Dave Lizewski, a high school student with no extraordinary abilities, no specialized training, and no moment of divine selection or traumatic awakening that would traditionally justify his transformation. Dave simply decides to become a superhero because no one else has tried. He orders a costume online, chooses a name, and walks out onto the streets of New York City expecting to do some good. What follows is not a rise to power. His first real attempt at heroism ends with him stabbed in the stomach and hit by a car. He survives, but the injuries leave him with nerve damage and metal plates in his skeleton, a grotesque parody of the origin story the formula expects. Instead of being granted power through destiny or sacrifice, Dave is merely broken enough to keep going. The film is aware of this irony. As Manohla Dargis wrote in *The New York Times*, the film simultaneously embraces and satirizes the conventions of superhero action, operating in a space where the genre's tropes are both performed and exposed.¹¹ Dave does gain a following. A bystander records one of his fights, and he becomes a viral sensation, not because he is effective but because the spectacle of someone actually trying is compelling enough on its own. But the attention does not make him better. The harder Dave tries, the deeper he falls into situations he is not equipped to handle. His efforts do not produce growth in the way Snyder's model predicts. They produce consequence. Each

¹¹ Manohla Dargis, "It's a Bird, It's a Plane, It's a Blood Bath," *The New York Times*, April 15, 2010.

intervention makes things worse, and the film never allows Dave the dignity of learning from his failures in a way that leads to mastery. He just suffers and nothing about that suffering makes him better at the job.. For most of the film, the real violence is being carried out by Big Daddy and Hit-Girl, characters who possess actual skill and who operate in a morally disturbing register of their own, while Dave watches from the margins of his own story. By the climax, Dave does step up. He does become the hero. The formula, after being bent and mocked for nearly two hours, ultimately reasserts itself, and the audience is given the triumphant payoff they were trained to expect. But the journey to that point has already done its damage. The hero wins, but only after the film has shown how unlikely and how costly that victory is.

Super

James Gunn's *Super* (2010) pushes the disruption further by removing any pretense that heroism is a rational or morally grounded decision. Where *Kick-Ass* gives its protagonist naivety and good intentions, *Super* gives its protagonist a psychotic break. Frank Darbo is a short-order cook whose wife leaves him for a drug dealer, and the loss sends him into a spiral of depression, isolation, and delusion. He does not arrive at heroism through inspiration or moral clarity. Frank arrives at it through a hallucination. In one of the film's most disturbing sequences, Frank experiences a vision in which his skull is peeled open, and his brain is physically touched by the finger of God. He interprets this as a divine calling to fight crime, and from that moment forward, he operates under the absolute conviction that his violence is sanctioned by a higher power. He builds a costume, names himself the Crimson Bolt, and begins patrolling the streets with a pipe wrench as his weapon of choice. The wrench is blunt and graceless, a weapon

superhero weapons are not supposed to be. Frank swings it at people's heads, and the film does not cut away from the damage. His targets are not supervillains. They are petty criminals, line-cutters, and people who have annoyed him, and the disproportionality of his response is the point. As one critic noted, the film functions as an astute parody of the traditional superhero origin story, because Frank's backstory is tragic in a way that is fundamentally different from that of a Peter Parker or Bruce Wayne.¹² His pain does not produce wisdom or responsibility. It produces obsession. He isn't learning to become a hero — he's using the framework of heroism to justify behavior the film frames as deeply unstable. This instability is compounded by the introduction of Libby, a comic book store employee who becomes Frank's sidekick under the name Boltie and who is, if anything, more unhinged than he is. She treats violence as recreation. She is giddy, reckless, and eager to escalate, and her presence forces the audience to confront the possibility that the superhero fantasy does not just attract the brave. It attracts people who are already broken. The audience is never fully invited to root for Frank because the film refuses to validate his worldview. There is no scene where his methods are proven right. There is no moment of clarity where the violence is revealed to have been necessary all along. The film withholds the moral payoff that Snyder's formula guarantees. It disrupts the expectation of protagonist likability, of moral clarity, and of healthy motivation, and replaces them with a character whose heroism is indistinguishable from his illness. If *Kick-Ass* asks what happens when someone without power tries to be a hero, *Super* asks what happens when the desire to be a hero is itself the symptom.

¹² Liam Gaughan, "15 Years Before 'Superman,' James Gunn Made This Darkly Funny Anti-Superhero Movie with Kevin Bacon," *Collider*, July 13, 2025.

Joker

Todd Phillips' *Joker* (2019) takes the logic of psychological instability that *Super* introduced and strips away everything comedic, everything ironic, and everything that might allow the audience to maintain distance. Where *Super* presents Frank's delusion with dark humor and absurdist framing, *Joker* presents Arthur Fleck's deterioration with the weight and texture of a 1970s character study, and that is not an accident. Phillips has been open about the film's lineage, citing Martin Scorsese's *Taxi Driver* (1976) and *The King of Comedy* (1982) as primary influences.¹³ Scorsese was initially attached to the project as a producer, directly involved in its early development before ultimately stepping away.¹⁴ His departure didn't erase his fingerprints from the project. The film that Phillips and Scott Silver built carries Scorsese's approach at a structural level. Psychological deterioration is the engine of the entire narrative, not a subplot within it. The connection to *Taxi Driver* in particular is structural. Both films follow isolated men living in decaying cities who feel abandoned by every system meant to support them. Both protagonists construct narratives of purpose out of that abandonment, convincing themselves that their growing capacity for violence is a form of moral response to a world that has failed them.¹⁵ Travis Bickle patrols the streets of New York in his taxi and decides he is the only person willing to act. Arthur Fleck rides the bus through Gotham and arrives at the same conclusion from a different direction. The difference is that *Taxi Driver* is an original work operating outside genre, while *Joker* maps that same psychological architecture onto the most recognizable genre framework in modern cinema: the superhero origin story. And in doing so, it inverts the formula

¹³ Noah Dominguez, "Joker: Todd Phillips Discusses Film's '70s Influence," *CBR*, September 2, 2019.

¹⁴ Chrishaun Baker, "Everything Joker Steals From Taxi Driver," *ScreenRant*, April 1, 2020.

¹⁵ *Taxi Driver*, directed by Martin Scorsese (Culver City, CA: Columbia Pictures, 1976).

entirely. Arthur's arc follows the shape of an origin story beat for beat: a traumatic past, a world that treats him cruelly, a slow accumulation of pressure, a transformation. But the transformation does not produce a hero. It produces a villain, and the film asks the audience to sit with the fact that the emotional machinery feels almost identical. The suffering that is supposed to forge a protector instead forges a destroyer, and the origin story framework, which normally provides moral clarity by its conclusion, instead reveals how easily that clarity can be manufactured. Arthur does not snap in a single dramatic moment. He deteriorates across the entire film. His social worker is cut off due to budget reductions. His medication is discontinued. His mother, the one person whose version of his childhood gave him something to hold onto, is revealed to have been complicit in his abuse. Each loss removes another point of contact between Arthur and the world, and each removal makes the next act of violence feel less like a choice and more like gravity. Variety's Owen Gleiberman described the film as a neo-Taxi Driver work in which Phoenix plays a mentally ill man who becomes the killer clown through a process that expresses something uncomfortably real about the world outside the theater.¹⁶ That discomfort is the point. *Joker* disrupts Snyder's model not by mocking it, the way *Kick-Ass* does, or by exposing its psychological foundations, the way *Super* does, but by using it sincerely and letting the audience feel how naturally the formula can produce something monstrous. The origin story is not refused. It is fulfilled, just not in the direction anyone was promised.

Chronicle

Josh Trank's *Chronicle* (2012) occupies a unique position within this tradition because it is the only film in this discussion where the protagonist receives real power and still becomes the

¹⁶ Owen Gleiberman, "Film Review: 'Joker,'" *Variety*, August 31, 2019.

villain. Andrew Detmer is a high school senior in Seattle. He is bullied at school, verbally and physically abused by his alcoholic father at home, and watching his mother die slowly of cancer. He films everything with a handheld camera, and the found footage format acutely displays his isolation. When Andrew, his cousin Matt, and their classmate Steve discover a mysterious crystalline object buried underground, all three of them develop telekinetic abilities. The early scenes are pure wish fulfillment. They move objects, play pranks, and learn to fly. They act exactly the way teenagers would act if they suddenly had superpowers, and for a stretch of the film, the audience is allowed to enjoy it alongside them. The formula seems to be working. Three young people receive extraordinary abilities, and the trajectory should be clear: they will grow into those abilities, face a challenge, and emerge as heroes. Steve is charismatic and confident. Matt is thoughtful and principled. But Andrew's suffering does not refine him. It compounds. The powers do not give him confidence or clarity. They give him leverage, and the more leverage he gains, the more visible the damage underneath becomes. A humiliating incident at a party sends him spiraling. His mother's condition worsens. His father's abuse intensifies. Each external pressure pushes Andrew further from the people who might have kept him grounded, and the powers that should have been his salvation become the instrument of his collapse. One critic described the film as a lo-fi superhero movie that is really about a supervillain, and that tension is what drives the entire second half.¹⁷ Andrew stops using his abilities for fun and starts using them to assert control over a world that has never given him any. He hurts people. He rationalizes it. He escalates. By the climax, he is levitating above the city in a scene of genuine destruction, and Matt, the cousin who tried to pull him back, is the one forced to stop him. The film ends with Andrew dead. There is no redemption, no last-minute reversal, no moment where the character realizes what he has become and chooses differently. The arc completes in the

¹⁷ Josh Larsen, "Chronicle," *Larsen on Film*. n.d.

worst possible direction, and the formula that was supposed to carry him to heroism instead delivers him to violence and death. What makes *Chronicle* essential to this project is the specificity of Andrew's failure. He is not incompetent like Dave Lizewski. He is not delusional like Frank Darbo. He is not a product of systemic neglect the way Arthur Fleck is, at least not entirely. Andrew has real power, real relationships, and a real opportunity to become something better. He has everything the formula says a hero needs except the internal stability to hold it together, and the film traces with painful clarity what happens when that one missing piece is the piece that matters most. For *The Eclipse*, that clarity is foundational. Elias follows a similar trajectory. He witnesses something that inspires him, he acts on that inspiration, and the formula tells him he is doing the right thing. But the formula does not account for what he lacks, and by the time that absence becomes visible, it is too late to correct.

Hancock

Hancock (2008) approaches the superhero formula from a direction that the other films in this discussion avoid. Dave Lizewski has no power. Frank Darbo has no power. Arthur Fleck has no power. *Hancock* has all of it. He is superhumanly strong, functionally invulnerable, and capable of flight. By every metric the genre uses to define a hero, he qualifies. The film's disruption comes from the fact that none of that matters, because *Hancock* is also an alcoholic, emotionally volatile, and completely indifferent to the collateral damage his interventions cause. He stops a car chase by landing on the vehicle and cratering the highway. He saves a man from an oncoming train and derails it in the process. He throws a beached whale back into the ocean and destroys a sailboat. Every act of heroism produces a secondary disaster, and the citizens of

Los Angeles hate him for it. His public reputation is one of embarrassment and frustration, and the city eventually calculates that he has caused more financial damage than the criminals he claims to be stopping. The formula assumes that power and virtue arrive together, that the person capable of saving the world is also the person emotionally equipped to do so. *Hancock* separates those two things completely. He has the strength the genre demands and none of the restraint, none of the wisdom, none of the self-awareness the formula quietly assumes comes packaged with it. This separation is what makes the film useful for understanding *The Eclipse*. One of the central ideas in Elias's story is that intent does not equal responsibility. Elias believes that choosing to act is inherently moral, that stepping in is always better than standing by. *Hancock* operates under a similar delusion. He believes that having the ability to help obligates him to do so, and he treats every situation as his to resolve, regardless of whether his involvement makes things worse. The difference is that *Hancock* is eventually confronted with this failure. A publicist takes him on as a project, forces him to reckon with his behavior, and restructures his public image. The film gives *Hancock* a redemption arc. He learns, adjusts, and earns back the city's trust. The formula bends but ultimately holds. *Hancock* gets to become the hero he was supposed to be all along, which means the audience gets the resolution they expect. The power-virtue equation is restored. But the first half of the film has already done its work. It has already shown what heroism looks like when the person behind it lacks the maturity to carry it, and that image lingers even after the narrative corrects course. The disruption is temporary, but the question it raises is permanent: what happens when the correction never comes?

Unbreakable

M. Night Shyamalan's *Unbreakable* (2000) operates differently from every other film in this discussion because it does something the formula rarely allows: it withholds the hero. The other films examined here give their protagonists costumes, names, and missions relatively early and then complicate what those things mean. *Unbreakable* spends its entire runtime on the question of whether its protagonist is a hero at all. David Dunn is a security guard in Philadelphia. When a catastrophic train derailment kills every other passenger onboard and leaves David without a single injury, the film does not treat this as an exciting revelation. It treats it as a problem. David does not want to be extraordinary. He is not seeking purpose or meaning or a calling. The discovery of his abilities arrives through Elijah Price, a comic book art dealer with a rare bone disorder that makes his body catastrophically fragile. Elijah has spent his life searching for someone at the opposite end of the spectrum, someone unbreakable, and he presents David with the possibility that superhero mythology is rooted in something real. The film unfolds as a slow, deliberate negotiation between David and that idea. He tests his strength. He begins to sense danger in the people around him through physical contact. His son, desperate to believe his father is something more, pushes him toward acceptance while his wife resists it. There are almost no action sequences. There is no training montage, no dramatic suit-up, no public debut. The genre's expected spectacle is completely absent. Shyamalan frames the film through long, quiet compositions that mimic comic book panels, but the energy of those frames is contemplative rather than kinetic. Quentin Tarantino praised the film as a brilliant retelling of the Superman mythology, and *Time* ranked it among the ten greatest superhero films ever made, describing it as a quiet and realistic exploration of the pressures that come with superhero

identity.^{18 19} What makes the film essential to understanding *The Eclipse* is the way it treats that identity as a burden. David Dunn does eventually accept who he is. In the film's final act, he puts on a hooded rain poncho that functions as his version of a cape, follows a disturbing vision to a home where a family is being held captive, and intervenes. It is one of the most understated heroic moments in the genre. There is no score swell, no triumphant pose, no public recognition. He saves the family, nearly drowns in a pool because water is his single vulnerability, and returns home. The next morning, he slides a newspaper across the breakfast table to his son, and a look passes between them that says everything the film has been building toward. The hero has arrived, but the film has made the audience wait so long and work so hard for that moment that it feels less like triumph and more like resignation. *Unbreakable* disrupts the superhero formula by refusing its pacing, its spectacle, and its emotional vocabulary. It replaces the excitement of becoming a hero with the exhaustion of realizing you might already be one and have been hiding from it your entire life. David is the hero. But the film has redefined what that means, and the version it offers feels closer to grief than to glory.

Breaking the Contract

The superhero formula that Snyder codifies depends on more than structure. It depends on allegiance. Snyder's "Save the Cat" rule is built on a simple principle: early in the story, the hero must do something that makes the audience like them and want them to succeed. He frames this as the essential first contract between the film and the viewer, the moment where the audience decides to invest. Everything that follows, the setbacks, the training, the climax, the

¹⁸"Quentin Tarantino's Favourite 20 Movies from 1992 to 2009," *Flicks.co.uk*, March 31, 2022.

¹⁹"Top 10 Superhero Movies," *Time*, June 3, 2011.

triumph, only works if that early alignment holds. The films examined here each find a different way to compromise that alignment, and together they map the full range of what happens when the contract is broken. Each film finds a different way to compromise that alignment. *Kick-Ass* keeps its protagonist outmatched by his own incompetence. *Super* goes further and makes sympathy itself feel dangerous. *Joker* forces the audience to watch understanding become the foundation for something horrific, while *Chronicle* refuses the transformation the formula promises outright. *Hancock*, by contrast, rebuilds the contract through a conventional redemption arc, and *Unbreakable* withholds the contract entirely. None of these films follow the same strategy, but they share a common refusal: the audience is never allowed to settle into the comfortable position Snyder's model assumes they will occupy from the start. Comfort is delayed, denied, manipulated, or earned at a cost that changes what it feels like when it arrives. Together, these films form a tradition of superhero storytelling that treats the audience's relationship to the protagonist as the most volatile element in the narrative rather than the most stable one. This is the tradition *The Eclipse* belongs to.

The Eclipse draws from this tradition and pushes past the boundary that each of these films, in its own way, still respects. *Kick-Ass* bends the formula and restores it. *Hancock* breaks the contract and repairs it. *Unbreakable* delays the hero and eventually confirms him. Even *Joker* and *Chronicle*, the two films that commit most fully to deterioration, operate within recognizable mythologies. Arthur Fleck becomes the Joker, a character the audience already knows, and that foreknowledge provides a kind of narrative safety net. The destination is dark, but it is familiar. Andrew Detmer's collapse is genuinely tragic, but the film ends with Matt carrying forward as a moral counterweight, someone who learned from what happened and chose differently. There is still a character left standing who represents the version of the story that went right. *The Eclipse*

offers none of that. Elias is not becoming a known villain. There is no existing mythology to contextualize his fall, no audience expectation about where the character is supposed to land. He is an original figure in an original world, which means the story has no obligation to deliver him anywhere recognizable. And it doesn't. His arc begins with genuine inspiration. He watches a real superhero die on live television and decides that someone needs to step up, that inaction is the greater failure, that choosing to do something is inherently better than choosing to do nothing. It is not delusional in the way Frank Darbo's divine vision is delusional, and it is not born from the kind of systemic damage that shapes Arthur Fleck. It is an earnest, deeply felt conviction, and that is what makes it so dangerous. Elias intervenes. He puts himself in harm's way. He tries to stop a robbery, and the clerk gets shot. He tries again somewhere else, and the outcome is worse. Each attempt to do the right thing generates consequences he cannot absorb, and instead of pausing to reckon with those consequences, he accelerates. The inaction belief becomes the engine of his escalation, because every failure feels like proof that he has not done enough rather than evidence that he should stop. When the violence eventually reaches someone he loves, someone he cannot rationalize losing, the arc does not bend toward reflection. It bends toward murder. The conventional hero story moves from struggle to triumph. The films discussed in this section move from struggle to complication, testing how much the formula can absorb before it collapses. The Eclipse skips the negotiation entirely. It moves from inspiration to intervention to escalation to collapse, and at no point does the narrative offer Elias a way back. He does not fail to become a hero and then recover. He fails and keeps going until he becomes something worse, and the story treats that progression as the inevitable result of a belief system that was never examined, only acted on. The helmets in the installation trace this arc physically. They degrade across the series the way Elias degrades across the story, moving from clean and

precise to broken and unrecognizable, and the viewer encounters them in sequence the same way an audience encounters a narrative: expecting progression, expecting resolution, and finding instead that the objects, like the character, only come apart.

Chapter 2: The Story

The Eclipse is set in 2004. It takes place in a version of America where superheroes exist and operate openly, where the public has grown accustomed to the presence of enhanced individuals, and where the line between ordinary life and extraordinary danger has become blurred enough that people accept it without question. Children grow up knowing the names of real heroes the way earlier generations knew the names of astronauts. At the center of this world stands The Phoenix, a golden-clad hero who has become the face of public safety and moral clarity for an entire generation.

The story begins with death

Footage surfaces on live television showing The Phoenix being killed by a villain in a Brooklyn basement. The video is shaky, hand-held, and filmed by the villain himself. He monologues directly into the camera about who he is and what he believes, and then The Phoenix breaks down the door behind him and engages his henchmen in a fight. She finishes them off. She approaches him. He turns, strikes her with a single brutal punch that sends her across the room, and the film follows him as he walks to where she has landed. She tries to build a final blast of energy. Her hands begin to glow. He lifts her by the throat and slams her to the floor, and in her last seconds, she speaks. Her words are fragmented, but their meaning is clear: there will always be someone else. Someone will rise. The villain tightens his grip, breaks her neck, and calls her predictable. The footage is leaked to a national news network. It plays on loop across cable for days.

Elias Bernman is a freshman at Ironclad University, a leading school in technological development, when he watches it. He is eighteen years old. He lives in a room filled with soldering equipment, half-finished prototypes, and scattered components from a wearable device he has been building since high school, modeled loosely after a fire extinguisher and intended for use by firefighters and pararescue operators. Elias has always believed that to have worth in the world is to have an impact on it, and that ability creates obligation. When The Phoenix's final words reach him through the television set, he does not experience them as rhetoric. He experiences them as instruction.

Fueltopia

The first intervention takes place outside a run-down gas station called Fueltopia. This scene exists in a longer piece of prose fiction I wrote for the project, which tells the story partly in first person from Elias's perspective. Short excerpts are included below.

The sad truth is that most evil is done by people who never make up their minds to be good or evil. The day it all happened was the Sunday I chose to be good.²⁰

Elias has no costume. He is dressed in pieces of Sam's lacrosse gear, which he borrowed after explaining that he needed padding, and pieces of his own inventions strapped to his arms. Sam is his closest friend from childhood. She attends Ironclad as well, plays lacrosse for the school, and has known Elias long enough to see through most of what he says about himself. She

²⁰ Zane Devlin, "Day One," unpublished creative writing, 2025.

stands beside him in the empty parking lot, holding a lacrosse stick, wearing cargo pants and a flannel. She has agreed to come with him because she does not trust him to go alone.

The argument they have in the parking lot is the first time Elias articulates his worldview aloud. He tells her that The Phoenix died, that a power vacuum has opened, that someone needs to step up. She tells him it is stupid. He tells her it is about trying. Before he can finish, a gunshot echoes from inside the store.

Sam runs. Elias watches her sprint across the parking lot, trip, hit the concrete hard, scramble back up, and keep going without looking back. He is alone.

I turned around, and I was about to take a big sigh when I thought about the conversation we just had. No, I was amped, I was ready for this. I can't sigh. And so looking up from the asphalt, I said under my breath, "A new hero will rise."

He walks into the store. The robbery is already in progress. The clerk is standing behind the counter with his hands up. A man in a ski mask is pointing a shotgun at him. There is already a shotgun hole in the ceiling from a warning shot. Elias enters, puffs out his chest, and begins his speech. He tells the robber his reign of terror ends today. The shotgun goes off. The clerk is hit. The robber is as startled as Elias is. He swears to himself that he thought the safety was on. He empties the register and starts to leave. On his way out, he stops and stands directly over Elias on the floor.

"Sorry you had to see that," he said.

The robber leaves. The clerk is still screaming. A song is playing faintly from an iPod behind the counter. It is only in the silence afterward that Elias identifies it: “In Too Deep” by Sum 41.

The scene establishes the unstable foundation of Elias's identity. He has not saved anyone. He has caused someone to be shot. The robber is more competent than he is, more grounded in reality, and more aware of what guns do to bodies. The formula the genre teaches promises that a failed first attempt is the beginning of a character's growth. Elias does not grow. He internalizes the experience as further proof that the world needs someone willing to show up.

The Solar Eclipse

Later that semester, the campus gathers on the football field to view a solar eclipse. Students stand with paper glasses, watching the moon move across the sun. “Black Hole Sun” by Soundgarden plays over the loudspeakers. The light changes. Birds go quiet. For a brief window, the middle of the day takes on the quality of dusk. Elias stands beside Sam and watches the totality arrive. The Phoenix's words come back to him. A new hero must rise. He tells Sam, quietly, that he thinks he knows how to keep them safe. Sam asks what he is thinking. He does not answer directly.

The eclipse is the image of what Elias is about to become. A figure passes in front of the source of light. The world below goes cold. People stand in a field and look up in awe, unaware that the thing they are watching is the shape of their own loss.

The Patrol

Over the following weeks, Elias continues to build. He refines his suit in the school's fabrication lab using material Emmet, a charismatic classmate from his advanced materials class, has helped him access. Emmet is warm, funny, socially fluent in a way Elias has never been, and a member of a fraternity called Epsilon. He is the first person at Ironclad to take Elias seriously. Elias keeps patrolling. He still wears pieces of Sam's lacrosse gear underneath his own improvised equipment, partly for the padding and partly because he has not yet made his own version. The gear belongs to Sam. Her name is stitched inside it, the way athletic gear always is. One night, Elias encounters a man selling drugs in an alley behind an off-campus bar. Elias intervenes. There is a scuffle. The man is stronger and more experienced than Elias, and in the struggle, he tears a piece of the lacrosse gear off Elias's body before Elias manages to break free and run. Elias goes home. He does not understand what he has just given away.

The man he fought was a member of Epsilon, in disguise as part of an internal fraternity operation that is never fully explained to Elias but is known to Emmet and the upper ranks of the brotherhood. Within days, Epsilon has identified Sam as the vigilante who attacked their member. Sam disappears shortly after that. There is no body. There is no note. Her parents file a report. The university issues a statement. The fraternity offers condolences through official channels. Rumors circulate. Some of them point toward Epsilon. Some of them are dismissed. Elias begins asking questions and finds that every door he knocks on has been closed in advance. The administration is sympathetic and unhelpful. The police are professional and unhelpful. Emmet is devastated on his behalf and unhelpful. Sam was taken because of Elias. The fraternity

believed she was the vigilante because her name was inside the gear he wore on a patrol he never told her about. His attempt to protect the city has killed the person closest to him, and he does not understand this yet.

The Party

Elias spirals. He stops attending class. He stops eating. In the weeks that follow, “Iris” by the Goo Goo Dolls plays over his life. He passes a missing-person notice on a carton of milk in the corner store with Sam's photo on it and has to walk out.

A few weeks after her disappearance, Emmet finds him on the quad and tells him gently that Epsilon is throwing a party that weekend. Emmet does not push. He tells Elias that grief isolates people and that it might help to be around others. Elias goes.

The party is loud. A crowded living room, red cups, a keg, classic rock bleeding into early-2000s pop. Elias drifts through the crowd nursing a drink he did not plan to drink and then another. He is already intoxicated when he passes a cluster of brothers in the dining room, one of whom has pulled a samurai sword off the wall and is holding it for a laughing girl. She asks if he is a samurai master. He smirks and corrects her. He tells her his title is Knight of Epsilon.

The word Knight lands inside Elias with a weight he does not immediately process. He loses his balance. Someone catches his elbow. He turns and realizes the person steadying him is Emmet. Emmet asks if he is okay. Elias mumbles that he has had too much. Emmet laughs, pats him on the back, and tells him that it is a good thing.

Elias stumbles away. Once he is clear of Emmet, the laughter falls off his face. He straightens up. He is piecing together the fragments he has been carrying for weeks, the

comments overheard at other parties, the name the man in the alley muttered during their fight, the way every door in the administration closed the moment he pushed on it. He grabs a bottle of liquor from a drunk girl on his way out. She protests. He does not hear her. Elias is not sober. He is arriving at certainty through grief, fury, and vodka, because sitting with uncertainty has become unbearable.

The Dark Night

In his room, Elias rages. He drinks from the stolen bottle. He paces. He tears at his own space. Flashes cycle through him: Sam sprinting across the parking lot, the clerk on the floor of Fueltopia, the fight in the alley, the man in the ski mask, Emmet laughing at the party. He ends up standing in front of the suit he has spent the whole semester building, the piece of equipment he designed to save people.

This is the thematic core of Elias's collapse. He has built his entire identity on the belief that action is morally superior to inaction, and now that belief becomes the logic of his descent. His principles, which once pointed him toward intervention in the lives of strangers, now point him toward a specific target. He has made a fatal leap from ambiguity to conviction. The story also refuses to pretend that the institutions around him deserved his patience, and that ambivalence is what makes the ending so difficult to resolve.

The Fraternity

Cut to the street outside the Epsilon house. The party has emptied out. A couple of brothers linger on the porch finishing drinks. Elias stands across the street in the suit he has spent the semester building, fully assembled for the first time. He is holding the handle of liquor he took from the party. He takes one last swig and throws the bottle into the gutter. It shatters on the pavement. He presses play on the iPod clipped to his belt.

Kanye West's "Jesus Walks" begins. The choice of song is deliberate. Kanye is a culturally polarizing figure whose public persona has become a referendum on ego, ambition, and self-mythology, and "Jesus Walks" is the song he wrote about faith as both conviction and performance. The lyrics treat moral certainty as a kind of righteous armor. Played in a different context, over a different protagonist, it would be the anthem of a hero arriving. Played over Elias walking across the street toward the house of a man who trusted him, it becomes the sound of a person who has convinced himself that what he is about to do is righteous, scored with a song that believes the same thing about itself.

Elias crosses the street. He takes out the two brothers sitting outside quickly and quietly, using a taser and a baton, neither of them seriously hurt. He enters the house. Elias battles through several fraternity brothers in a prolonged fight that destroys his suit. In the basement, he finds Emmet. Elias kills Emmet. The story does not give him the relief of a confession. It does not confirm whether Emmet personally ordered what happened to Sam. It does not even confirm that Sam is dead. Elias crawls out a window, and the story ends with Elias on a hill, watching the fraternity house burn to the ground. The final image is meant to be chilling.

Chapter 3: Interdisciplinary Methodology

The Eclipse takes the form of sculpture and installation, but the project is shaped equally by filmmaking, writing, digital modeling, and printmaking. The combination of these areas is what allowed the project to develop into a world rather than a single object. The interdisciplinary nature of the Art, Science & Innovation major became essential for building something that operates across narrative, material, and conceptual levels. The project could not exist without ASI, Filmmaking, Writing, Fabrication, and Study Abroad. Each of those areas contributed something the others could not provide on their own, and the final installation is a record of the places where those disciplines intersected.

ASI and Fabrication

ASI gave me the ability to prototype, test, and iterate. Understanding machines as creative partners is central to the major, and the helmets in this project rely on digital fabrication as both a technical and narrative tool. The tools I used include 3D printing, Blender modeling, laser cutting, photogrammetry, and material testing with epoxy, silicone, EVA foam, plaster, and fiberglass. None of these tools existed in isolation for me. Each one entered the project through a specific class, collaboration, or moment of troubleshooting, and the sum of those moments is the reason the helmets exist.

During my junior seminar, I learned to use photogrammetry with nothing more than my cellphone and the help of a friend. He took hundreds of photos of my head from every angle while I stood still in a well-lit room. Different applications processed the images in different

ways, sending them to cloud servers where the photos were computed and triangulated into a three-dimensional scan. I tested several apps to figure out which ones handled facial structure best, how different lighting conditions affected the quality of the mesh, and how much interference hair created. I borrowed a swim cap from another friend to keep my hair flat, which dramatically improved the scan quality. The finished model was meant to serve as a base on which I could design the original prototype helmet. It was only later that I realized I could 3D print the scan itself and have a physical version of my own head to work with, which would become a core piece of the installation.

The design process began on paper. I sketched versions of the prototype helmet for the course, cycling through different silhouettes and proportions before committing to a direction. From there, I moved the sketches into Blender. This was the most challenging part of the project to learn. I consulted Keven Duverglas, a peer I had worked with during my freshman year on a 3D model of my brand name, and he taught me the foundations of the program, how to import my sketches, and how to approach modeling a complex form. I learned to trace the helmet out in sections, building the shape in low resolution first so that I could control the overall structure, and then gradually increasing the resolution as I refined the details. The modeling process was slow and often frustrating, but it taught me how digital form is built.

My experience with laser cutting came from two different scenarios. The first was during a Materials & Fabrication course with Professor Brand, who taught me how to operate the machine so that I could monitor it during her class while students in the course were using it. I started auditing the course so I could see how students approached different projects, and even though I never produced a piece of my own during that time, I watched at least a dozen projects pass through the machine. The second scenario came during my lab hours, when a student named

Kendra asked for help troubleshooting a project she was working on for her own comp. I was able to identify a set of small technical adjustments that improved the quality of her cuts and the behavior of the laser at different intensities and speeds. One of the issues I remember specifically was that the wood was warping in a way that was preventing her puzzle pieces from fitting together, and the fix came from adjusting the intensity rather than the speed.

There were other moments that expanded what I understood about the machine. I spent time talking with Professor Lumen about different projects he was working on, including a replica of a View-Master toy made from laser-cut cardboard and a set of custom-engraved letters. I asked other professors about the miscellaneous things they were cutting and engraving, and I worked with someone on engraving glass plaques. None of these conversations were part of a formal course, but each of them added something to my understanding of what the laser could do and how different materials respond to it.

When I began my senior year, I started working with Professor Thomas on mold making and casting, neither of which I had any background in. He taught me when to use different methods and which materials worked best in different situations. He showed me how to use brush-on silicone to capture a mold of my 3D-printed head, and how to reinforce it with a thicker layer using a powder-based thickening agent. I learned how to add registration keys and where to place them, and how to build a fiberglass mother mold to support the silicone during casting. Every one of these processes was a chemical reaction, and learning to work with them meant learning to experiment with them directly, to observe how different brands and ratios produced different results, and to develop intuition for what a given material was going to do before it did it.

Filmmaking Skills

Filmmaking shaped this project long before any physical object existed. The Eclipse began as a screenplay, and the thinking I developed through my filmmaking minor is visible in the installation at a level most viewers will not consciously register, but which governs how the entire space is organized.

The installation is designed to feel like a room rather than a gallery display. A place that belongs to someone, with furniture and objects arranged the way a set designer would arrange them for a scene. Each helmet in that space represents a specific moment in Elias's story, a narrative beat the way a beat functions in a screenplay. The viewer moves through the helmets the way a film moves through its acts, and the degradation across the series operates as visual continuity, the same tool a film uses when it tracks a character's costume deteriorating across a story.

The other filmmaking instinct that shaped this project is the stunt double system. On a real film set, no hero prop is a single object. Every helmet, every weapon, every costume piece is built in multiple versions, each engineered for a specific use. There is a hero version for close-ups, built with detail and precision. There are stunt versions, lighter and more forgiving, built to survive being worn during action. There are distressed versions for later in the story when the character has been through something. There are versions sized to fit the lead actor and versions sized to fit a stunt performer who is not the same height or head size. The audience sees all of them as one object on screen, but the prop department knows each one as a separate build with a separate job to do. Approaching my own work the way a prop department would meant thinking about weight, durability, scale, and interchangeability in ways I would not have

considered if I had been building a single sculpture. It also meant recognizing that the objects in the installation are not artifacts of one imagined film production. They are artifacts of how film production functions.

Writing and Narrative Design

Writing is the backbone of this project. Every physical object in the installation exists because the story needed it to exist, and every decision about what the objects look like was a decision that started on the page. My writing minor gave me the foundation for building characters who develop, fracture, and rebuild over time, and *The Eclipse* would not have held together without that training.

The story came first. I developed Elias as a character before I designed the helmets, and the helmets became possible only once I understood who he was and what was happening to him across the arc. Each helmet represents a specific version of the character at a specific moment in the story, and the degradation across the series is a physical translation of what writing the story taught me about his collapse. The first helmet is clean because Elias is still at the beginning of his belief in himself. The last helmet is broken because he is. The objects could not have been designed in any other order. I had to know the character to know the damage.

Writing also taught me how to think about what is not shown. A story communicates as much through what it withholds as through what it reveals, and that lesson carried directly into the installation. The helmets do not depict events. They imply them. A viewer who does not know the story can still read the progression from clean to ruined and feel that something has

happened, and that feeling is doing the work of narrative without ever stating it aloud. This is a principle I learned through writing and applied through sculpture.

The prose fiction I produced for this project, including the first-person retelling of the gas station scene that appears in the previous chapter, is part of the installation's broader ecosystem. It exists as another surface on which the character lives, and the voice of that writing, first person, reflective, quietly self-incriminating, is the voice that shapes everything else the viewer encounters in the space.

Italy

During my third year at Allegheny, I studied abroad in Rome, where I spent months working in printmaking and screenprinting. I came away with two habits that changed how I approach material work.

My professor pushed me to experiment. She encouraged me to make random things without a fixed plan, chase whatever caught my eye, and keep going until something in the results was worth refining. Once I had something worth repeating, the job became curating and reproducing it deliberately. This is the part of my process that shows up in the helmet fabrication, where I experimented with materials and finishes until I found the kind of damage that looked right, and then reproduced it across other pieces.

The engineer I worked with taught me the technical side. Printmaking is a discipline built on cleanliness and order. You need clean tools, clean surfaces, and clean hands. He described the process as being "like surgery," and the comparison was accurate. A single smudge can ruin a piece that took hours to set up. That discipline carried into every part of this project. Mold

making, resin casting, airbrushing, and screenprinting all collapse the moment the workspace stops being clean.

The feather-and-scale pattern on the balaclavas came out of both approaches. I developed it through open experimentation and refined it into something repeatable, and it eventually became the screenprinted layer under every helmet in the installation.

Chapter 4: Fabrication and Process

The project took nearly a year to build and drew on every fabrication discipline I had picked up during college. This section is written with future students in mind. Where possible, I have named specific products, machines, and techniques so that someone working on a similar project can use this document as a starting point rather than trying to reverse-engineer every decision on their own.

Influences

Before I get into the build itself, I want to name three influences that shaped how I thought about this work.

The first is Jacqueline Durran's costume design for *The Batman* (2022).²¹ A book I studied during early research walked through the full concept art and prop development for the film, and what stood out to me was how much of the design philosophy came from the idea that a superhero costume should look assembled rather than manufactured. Visible seams, hand-built panels, and surfaces that read as the work of a real person with real tools.

The second is Stephanie Maslansky's costume work on the Netflix *Daredevil* series, which directly influenced the eyepiece design for my helmets.²²

²¹ James Field, *The Art of The Batman* (New York: Abrams Books, 2022).

²² Chi Minh-Ha, "'Daredevil' Has More Than One Superhero Costume and Tons of Designer Clothes," *Fashionista*, April 10, 2015, <https://fashionista.com/2015/04/daredevil-costume-design>.

The third is the Adam Savage Tested video, breaking down the Wolverine suit built for *Deadpool & Wolverine* by FBFX.²³ That video walks through the full assembly of a real production superhero suit, including interviews with the costume designers about how each layer functions, and it became a reference for how I thought about the relationship between structure and surface in my own builds.

The Master Helmet

The starting point was a redesigned version of the prototype I had developed in my junior seminar. I began on paper, sketching new variations until I had a design I felt committed to. I then transferred the drawing into Blender, treating the digital model as a refinement of the sketch rather than a replacement for it. Improving mainly on how the pieces fit together. An issue I had with the original. Once the model was finalized, I 3D printed it in two major pieces at the ALIC facility at Bessemer: a front half and a back half that fit together cleanly.

The printed surface came off the machine covered in visible layer lines, which meant the next stage of the process was subtractive. I used Rustoleum sandable filler primer, applied in layers, sanding between each coat until every layer line was gone and the surface was completely smooth. This is a slow process. It is hours of spraying, waiting, and sanding. This stage is where most of the visible quality of a 3D printed prop is created. Skipping it or rushing it will make every later stage of the build look worse.

²³ Adam Savage, "How Wolverine's Costume Was Created for Deadpool & Wolverine!," *Tested*, YouTube, June 24, 2024, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AkvNYMghruM>.

The Mold System

To produce multiple variants of the helmet at the level of detail the project required, I had to make molds of the master. The front half and the back half each got their own mold, built similarly but using slightly different techniques.

For the back half, I built a cardboard shell around the printed piece using hot glue. I used plasticine to smooth the edges where the cardboard met the helmet so that the seam between the mold wall and the object would be clean. I filled the shell with a two-part silicone from Smooth-On, let it cure, and removed the helmet once the silicone had fully set.

The front half, I used brush-on silicone, applied in layers and built up thick enough to hold its own shape. Attached registration keys and then built a cardboard shell and poured a plaster mother mold.

This gave me a single-piece mold I could use to cast the front and back halves of both the Penumbra and the Totality helmets. Both of the cast halves were poured in Onyx Fast, a Smooth-On resin that cures quickly and produces a rigid, durable piece with a fine surface finish.

The Stunt Double Variants

The foam helmets on the bar side of the installation were built using a completely different process. Three of them were built as stunt double variants of the main fireplace helmets, one for each of Phoenix, Penumbra, and Totality. A fourth foam helmet was built separately for use in the “Tubthumping” music video.²⁴ The foam helmets are not cast. They are paneled.

I taped up the 3D printed master with masking tape and outlined each panel of the helmet with a Sharpie, then cut the tape panels out and flattened them onto paper. I scanned those flattened shapes, cleaned them up in Illustrator, and turned them into laser-cut files. The foam pieces were cut from 5mm EVA foam and assembled with DAP contact cement.

The Tubthumping helmet was the first foam build, and it is also the one I learned the most from. For that helmet, I laser cut an additional set of 2mm panels and glued them on top of the main shell to create a raised panel look. The process worked, but took a long time. Once it was finished, I realized I could achieve a similar visual effect with less labor. On the later foam builds, the Phoenix and Penumbra stunt doubles, I skipped the additional panel layer entirely, and instead laser etched a shallow perimeter line around the edge of each panel, which creates the visual illusion of raised paneling when the helmet is viewed from any normal distance. The time savings were significant, and the result reads almost identically. This is a lesson in doing the harder version first. Building the full raised-panel version taught me what the panels were actually contributing, and that knowledge is what made the shortcut possible.

The foam helmets received different finishing treatments depending on their role. The Tubthumping helmet was finished with Plasti-Dip. The Totality stunt double received the same

²⁴ Zane Devlin, dir., “Chumbawamba – Tubthumping,” YouTube, 2026, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PaPgR2zqfUc>.

Plasti-Dip finish, leaving it black. It also received silicone caulking in the seams to hide them. The Phoenix and Penumbra stunt doubles were coated in Epsilon Pro, another Smooth-On product, which produces a harder surface suitable for higher-detail finishing. All of the foam helmets except Totality were airbrush-painted. Totality was left black from the Plasti-Dip stage because that flat black surface matched the character's final state better than anything I could paint over it.

The Nose Pieces

Every helmet in the installation carries a nose piece that attaches to the front half. The nose pieces are all 3D printed. I removed the layer lines using Epsilon Pro as a coating, sanded the surface smooth, and painted them with high-gloss black spray paint. Once the paint had set, I added a thin additional layer, and while it was still tacky, I applied chrome nail polish powder to produce a copper-like finish. The technique comes from nail art, but the result is a metallic surface that reads as real, worked copper without requiring any actual metalworking.

The Eye Piece

The eyepiece was carried over unchanged from my junior seminar prototype. I chose to keep it rather than redesign it because the shape already worked. The design draws directly from the Netflix *Daredevil* series.²⁵ The costume designer Stephanie Maslansky says she built a mask

²⁵ *Marvel's Daredevil*, created by Drew Goddard (New York: Netflix, 2015–2018).

whose eye openings communicate emotion and threat at the same time.²⁶ And that is something I tried to carry into my own mask.

To reproduce the eye piece across multiple helmets, I made a mold of it using two-part Smooth-On silicone, built a cardboard shell around it the same way I built the helmet molds, and cast the eye pieces in Smooth-Cast 57D, which is a flexible resin. Because the cast pieces were flexible, I coated them in black Plasti-Dip to give them a consistent matte surface similar to that of leather.

The Cast Heads

Every helmet in the installation is displayed on a cast of my own head. That cast originates from the 3D printed head I produced during my junior seminar using photogrammetry. I molded it using brush-on silicone, added registration keys at stress points where the mold would be most likely to shift during casting, and built a fiberglass mother mold around it using clay as a barrier down the center of the head so the two halves of the mother mold could separate cleanly. All of the display heads were cast in pottery plaster.

To mount the heads consistently, I built a rig from scrap wood that ensured every cast head received a two-inch wooden dowel set at the same angle. This dowel is what connects the head to the wooden base beneath it. The rig is a small detail, but it matters. Without it, each head would sit at a slightly different angle, and the visual coherence of the installation would be lost. A jig like this is often the difference between a display that reads as a series and a display that reads as a collection.

²⁶ Minh-Ha, "'Daredevil' Has More Than One Superhero Costume."

The Wooden Bases

The bases were cut from plywood. I traced out the circles using a compass. Eight at thirteen inches, and six at six inches. I cut them on a bandsaw. The edges were cleaned up on a belt sander and then beveled using a router, which gives the bases a softer profile that reads more like furniture than display hardware. All of the wood was finished with a water-based polyurethane stain and sealer.

The bases were intentionally designed to feel domestic rather than institutional. This decision comes from the installation plan, which is described in the next section, but it bears mentioning here because the finishing choices on the wood were made with that goal in mind. A high-gloss lacquer or a raw industrial finish would read as gallery hardware. A warm stained poly reads as something you might find in a living room.

The Balaclavas

Each cast head wears a balaclava beneath its helmet. The balaclavas carry a pattern I developed during my study abroad in Italy, a feather-and-scale design I created during my printmaking coursework. I had the pattern exposed onto a silk screen for screenprinting, thanks to Professor Eberhardt. Using plastisol ink with a stretch additive, I printed the pattern onto milliskin matte spandex. I produced roughly twelve black balaclavas and six red ones, all printed with black plastisol. After printing, each piece was lightly heat-gunned to set the ink, then finished with an iron and parchment paper to complete the curing process.

The balaclavas themselves were sewn from patterns I developed using techniques I learned in Uriel Gomez's costume design class. I built the pattern the old-fashioned way, pinning trim directly onto a blank dress form to establish seam lines and then pinning cheesecloth over those seam lines to draft a working pattern. An elastic trim was added around the face opening, and the final pieces were assembled on a topstitch sewing machine. Uriel assisted with the final assembly.

The Plaques

Each helmet's base carries a copper-finished plaque with its title, subtitle, and Roman numeral counter. The plaques are cut from an aluminum sheet anodized with a copper finish, a material I sourced from Home Depot. The challenge with anodized aluminum is that it is copper on the face, but silver aluminum underneath, which means laser etching the text exposes the silver interior and makes the text almost impossible to read against the copper field. To solve this, I spray-painted the entire sheet in high-gloss black, then laser-etched everything except the text away. The result is black paint removed from the field, leaving the original copper anodizing exposed as the background, with the text appearing in the copper color because the black paint was never removed from that area. The plaques were then cut out of the sheet using a large metal shear. A clear coat was applied over each finished plaque to protect the paint.

The plaque process is a reminder that working with a material sometimes means working against it. The copper anodizing was not going to give me readable text on its own. The solution was to paint over it, etch into the paint, and let the material underneath do exactly what I needed it to do.

Chapter 5: Installation and Storytelling in Space

The installation is designed to feel like a room in someone's home. Not a gallery display, not a workshop, not a display case. A room. The kind of room that exists in many houses, regardless of size, where the people who live there put the things that matter to them. Sometimes it is the father's den or man cave. Sometimes it is the mother's nook or office. Sometimes it is a hallway alcove or a finished corner of a basement. It is always there, in some form, a small and personal space that quietly announces what the people inside the house care about. That is the vibe this installation is reaching for.

This is not Tony Stark's lab. The room belongs to a person, and the objects inside it are personal. They are displayed the way a family displays trophies on a mantel or photographs on a shelf, with attention and care, but without fanfare. The viewer who walks into the space should feel like they have stepped into a part of someone's home where the private mythology of the household is kept.

The Reference

The clearest cinematic reference for this feeling is a scene from the second season of *Peacemaker*. John Cena's character enters an alternate dimension where his doppelgänger is a famous superhero, and walks through a private library filled with artifacts and costumes from the other Chris's career.²⁷ That library is the emotional reference point for this installation. The difference is that my room belongs to a person whose mythology collapsed, which means every

²⁷ *Peacemaker*, season 2, created by James Gunn (Burbank, CA: HBO Max, 2025).

object inside it carries a different weight than the ones in Chris Smith's library. They are still personal. They are still displayed with care. But they are also the wreckage of a belief system.

The Layout

The layout is built around two pieces of furniture that anchor the space. On the left sits a TV stand-fireplace unit. On the right sits a plywood bar built to match. Between them, a CRT television plays the music video that incorporates the project. A leather chair is positioned in front of the CRT for viewers to sit in. A framed graduation photo hangs on a nearby wall, photoshopped to read "03" to reinforce the early 2000s setting.

To the left of the fireplace, a plant stand holds the lacrosse helmet that represents the Origin. It sits at roughly the same height as the other display pieces, but it is separated from the fireplace grouping so that it reads as something earlier and smaller, a thing that existed before the rest of the story began.

Each helmet is displayed on a cast of my own head, mounted on a wooden base, with a copper-finished plaque identifying it. The three narrative helmets are named for the phases of a solar eclipse. Phoenix is the uneclipsed sun — Elias's inherited image of what a hero looks like. Penumbra is the partial shadow, where the character still resembles himself, but something has started to fall across him. Totality is full occlusion, the moment the original light source is gone, and only the outline remains. Read in sequence, the titles trace the same arc as the object and the character. The three stunt double variants sit on the bar, mirroring their narrative counterparts and revealing the production logic behind the objects. The Tubthumping helmet, the one worn by Saul Mesa in the music video, sits among them.

The room carries other objects as well, arranged around the chair and the surrounding furniture. A suitcase sits next to the leather chair with the music video costume partially visible inside it, as if it had just been opened or was about to be packed away. A side table to the right of the chair holds a pen holder engraved with the phrase "God Answers Prayer." A wooden crucifix, a wooden telescope, and a wooden atlas are placed throughout the room. Exact placement of these smaller objects is still being decided, but each of them is meant to reinforce the feeling that a specific person lives here, someone with their own beliefs, their own curiosities, and their own quiet life outside of whatever the helmets represent. A home accumulates these kinds of objects over time, and a room that wants to feel like a home has to carry them too.

Why It Matters

This room is the closest I can get to showing a viewer how this character is actually kept. Not in a museum. Not in a lab. In a home. The helmets are not trophies of a hero. They are the private records of a character who exists in my head and now exists in this room and the room is designed so that anyone who walks into it can feel that weight, even if they do not yet know the story. Every decision in the space, the domestic furniture, the warm finishes, the graduation photo, the CRT, the leather chair, is there to hold that feeling. That is the emotional truth of the installation.

Documentation

































Conclusion

This project allowed me to discover the artist I've become. I realized that I am not a sculptor or a filmmaker or a writer, I am all of them at once. The Eclipse is the first time I have used every part of my education simultaneously, and the result is a work that reflects not only a character's transformation but my own. Over the course of building it, I came to understand that the disciplines I had been studying separately were never actually separate.

The project became an investigation into how objects can carry narrative weight. I discovered aspects of the character that would not have emerged from writing alone. Making the helmets revealed who Elias was and how he changed over time, and it informed the story. The clean first iteration told me what he believed about himself at the beginning. The broken last iteration told me what had happened to that belief by the end. Every degradation decision I made in the fabrication pushed something new to the surface in the writing, and every scene I wrote in the story fed back into the next helmet's design. The writing, the filmmaking, and the fabrication were recursive, and each pass through them made the next pass possible.

The project also pushed me to learn techniques I had never worked with before. I am leaving Allegheny with a fabrication range I did not have when I started, and that range exists because this project required it. The Eclipse asked more of me technically than anything I had built before, and the process of meeting those demands is what made the project possible at all.

More than anything, this comp taught me how to think about the relationship between story and object. The helmets are not illustrations of the story. They are the story, translated into material. The installation is not a gallery display. It is a room that belongs to someone, arranged with the quiet attention that people pay to the objects that matter to them. The music video is not

a supplement to the sculpture. It is the moment where the sculpture comes alive, and the character walks through a space the audience has been standing in the whole time. None of these decisions would have made sense to me four years ago. All of them make sense now because the project forced me to find out how they connect.

The Eclipse ultimately reflects the entire arc of my time at Allegheny. It brings together writing, filmmaking, fabrication, and printmaking into one unified project, and it traces a character whose collapse mirrors the tradition of superhero storytelling I have spent this paper analyzing. I set out to build a villain origin story that refused the conventional arc of the hero. I built one. The character does not survive his own convictions, and the audience is not offered a redemption that was never earned. What the project gave me in return is a working understanding of what I am capable of making, and The Eclipse is the first time I was ready to make it. It will not be the last.

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